INDEPENDENT RESEARCH | INTANGIBLE CULTURAL HERITAGE

TO WHAT EXTENT DOES THE COMMERCIALIZATION OF FACE-CHANGING INFLUENCE THE PUBLIC PERCEPTION AND THE ARTISTIC INTEGRITY OF SICHUAN OPERA?

231 VALID QUESTIONNAIRES | IBM SPSS STATISTICS | DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS & SPEARMAN'S RANK CORRELATION

01 | INTRODUCTION

Sichuan Opera is one of the representative traditional theatrical arts in southwestern China, whose artistic system encompasses not only face-changing but also singing, recitation, acting and martial arts.

Commercialization has provided new channels for the dissemination of Sichuan Opera. However, the expansion of the dissemination scope does not mean that the public has a deeper understanding of Sichuan Opera. The face-changing in traditional Sichuan Opera is usually associated with the characters' personalities, emotional changes and the plot progress, while some commercial performances place emphasis on the number of masks change and visual appeal.

RESEARCH QUESTION

To what extent does the commercialization of face-changing influence the public perception and the artistic integrity of Sichuan Opera?

02 | LITERATURE REVIEW

Commercialization & Cultural Visibility

Taking the Sichuan Opera face-changing performance of Haidilao as an example, integrating face-changing into catering can enhance the visibility of traditional culture and expose the culture to audiences who rarely know about Sichuan Opera. However, commercialization might lead to excessive simplification of performance.

Artistic Function & Adaptive Authenticity

Face-changing was originally closely related to dramatic plots and character development, using changes in facial makeup to express characters' emotions, personalities and psychological changes.

The framework of "Adaptive Authenticity" argues that traditional art does not have to choose between completely preserving the original form and commercial innovation. Instead, it can appropriately adjust non-core elements such as performance rhythm while protecting the core artistic contents.

03 | METHODOLOGY

Research Design & Sampling

This study adopted a cross-sectional research design, collecting data in the same stage to analyze the relationships among different variables.

This study collects data through online questionnaires and adopts opportunity sampling. A total of 231 valid questionnaires are obtained. The respondents include people who have watched Sichuan Opera and those who have not. The questionnaire adopts a skip logic.

231	181	134
VALID RESPONSES	OPERA / FACE-CHANGING VIEWERS	COMMERCIAL PERFORMANCE VIEWERS

Questionnaire & Data Analysis

The questionnaire design is mainly divided into four parts: demographic information; exposure and public perception of Sichuan Opera; evaluation of commercial face-changing performances; and artistic integrity.

In this study, IBM SPSS Statistics software is used for descriptive statistics and Spearman's rank correlation analysis. The Spearman correlation coefficient (ρ) is used to measure the direction and intensity of the relationship between variables, and the p value is used to determine statistical significance, with $p < 0.05$ being taken as the significance criterion. However, correlation does not prove a causal relationship between variables.

04 | RESULTS

4.1 Sample Profile

The sample is concentrated in Sichuan and Chongqing (88.7%). Respondents aged 26–60 account for 59.7% of the sample; 66.7% are female, and 65.4% hold a bachelor's degree or above.

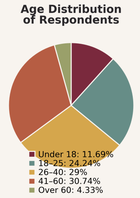


Figure 1. Age distribution

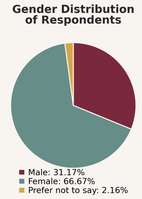


Figure 2. Gender distribution

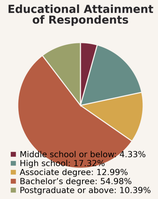


Figure 3. Educational attainment

4.2 Public Understanding & Access

Among the 181 people who have watched Sichuan Opera, 40.3% have reported having little or no knowledge of Sichuan Opera while only 7.7% are regarded as relatively or very familiar with it.

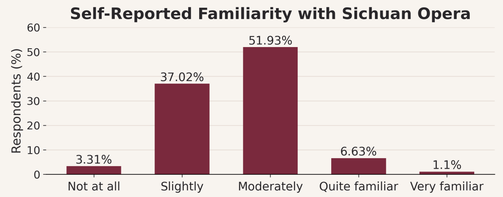


Figure 4. Self-reported familiarity with Sichuan Opera

TV is used mostly (48.1%) as the first channel of exposure, along with theatrical shows (42.5%), short videos (38.7%), and social networks (36.5%).

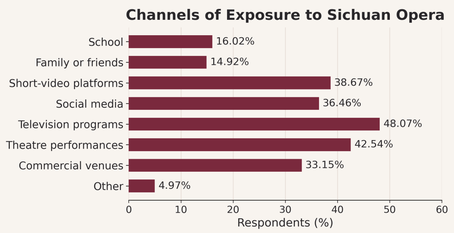


Figure 5. Channels of exposure to Sichuan Opera

4.3 Commercial Performance Evaluation

Among the 134 respondents who report watching commercial face-changing performances, 46.3% rate the performances as good or very good, while 51.5% rate them as average. Respondents most clearly recognize their promotional value, with 65.7% agreeing or strongly agreeing that they help promote Sichuan Opera.

65.7%	30.6%	34.3%
PROMOTIONAL VALUE	INTEREST SPARKED	WILLING TO LEARN MORE

4.4 Views on Artistic Integrity

A large majority agree that face-changing can be an entry point for learning more about Sichuan Opera (82.3%) and that it is one of the art form's many artistic components (79.0%). In addition, 77.9% emphasize protecting the complete artistic system.

At the same time, 70.2% believe that public understanding often remains focused on face-changing, and 59.7% worry that its popularity may lead audiences to overlook other artistic values.

82.3%	79.0%	59.7%
ENTRY POINT	ONE OF MANY COMPONENTS	CONCERN ABOUT OVERLOOKING

4.5 Correlation Analysis

More favorable evaluations of commercial face-changing are associated with stronger interest in Sichuan Opera ($\rho = .442$, $p < .001$), greater willingness to explore its wider artistic value ($\rho = .370$, $p < .001$), and stronger recognition of its promotional role ($\rho = .472$, $p < .001$).

Variables	ρ	p
Evaluation & interest	.442	<.001
Evaluation & exploration	.370	<.001
Evaluation & promotion	.472	<.001
Theatre & understanding	.255	<.001
Limited understanding & concern	.441	<.001
Entry point & artistic protection	.573	<.001

Agreement that public understanding remains focused on face-changing is moderately associated with concern that audiences may overlook other artistic values ($\rho = .441$, $p < .001$). Agreement that face-changing can be an entry point is strongly associated with prioritizing the protection of the complete art form ($\rho = .573$, $p < .001$).

05 | DISCUSSION

This study shows that commercial face-changing performances play an important role in attracting the public to come into contact with Sichuan Opera, but such contact does not necessarily translate into a deep understanding of it.

These results indicate that recognizing the promotion effect of face-changing and emphasizing the integrity of art are not contradictory. Therefore, commercialization itself does not necessarily harm Sichuan Opera.

06 | RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on my learning experience of Sichuan opera and previous studies, I believe commercial venues could cooperate with professional Sichuan opera troupes to maintain the accessibility and visual appeal of commercial performances while incorporating more of the art form's theatrical elements.

COMMERCIAL VENUES × PROFESSIONAL SICHUAN OPERA TROUPES

Troupes can provide performances and assist in designing brief character and plot introductions. The performances could incorporate plot segments related to face-changing and have narrators explain how face-changing serves character expression.

Commercial venues could introduce relevant plays through performance lists or QR codes and cooperate with troupes to recommend tourists to watch the complete and professional performance in theaters.

07 | LIMITATIONS

The sampling bias may exist because respondents mainly come from Sichuan and Chongqing, with a relatively high proportion of female respondents. Familiarity, interest, views on the integrity of art, and willingness to consume were all from respondents' self-reports.

Finally, correlation analysis can only indicate the connection between different responses, but it cannot establish a cause-and-effect relationship.

CONCLUSION **Commercialization itself does not necessarily undermine the artistic integrity of Sichuan Opera. The key lies in whether commercial performances retain the necessary plot and character expression, as well as whether they can guide the audience to come into contact with the complete play.**

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